Starting small: the first pieces from what already exists

Oct 18, 2026 · @Ace

Nobody makes our locket yet. The closest part on sale is an empty hunter case that pocket-watch factories sell for laser engraving. But no listing showed its size, metal, price or minimum. So the start is a test. Ask for a case of 40 mm or less, in low-lead brass or 316L steel, with your lid pattern lasered on. Buy it in tens and finish it in Seoul. If it exists at the estimated $3 to $6, it keeps the retro design. It also cuts the most cash you need at once, from about ₩7.2M to ₩4.9M. On cost per locket it only just meets the target: it misses above about ₩7,400 an engraving job, or about $4.95 a case. The generic photo pocket watch is cheaper to buy, and the wrong thing to sell.

The short answer

Your question	The answer
Is there a manufacturer already?	Not for our locket. No maker, wholesaler or print-on-demand platform sells a small brass hunter-case locket with no movement. The closest lead is one listing for an empty hunter case sold for laser engraving. It showed no size, metal, price or minimum, and it is probably the 45 mm alloy kind, so the week-3 answer may well be no. Working quartz pocket watches sell from 5 to 10 pieces, and Guangzhou brass makers take custom-logo orders from 2 to 30.
In what form?	An empty hunter case: crown, bow, hinged lid, crystal and a blank back, with no movement. The factory lasers your pattern on the lid. Seoul does the rest: your dial set to the couple's time, real hands, the photo, the engraving, the box and the letter.

Your question	The answer
Retro and customisable, or a generic stopwatch?	Retro and customisable. The generic photo watch is about 45 mm and quartz, with the photo lasered on the outer lid. It sells as a $20 to $90 groomsmen gift. It can carry about ₩45,000, not ₩79,000, and Wadiz won't take it.
Does it meet the cost target?	Only just, on the middle estimates: about ₩22,700 a locket against the ₩24,200 target, the cost the plan's prices were set on. Built to the same spec it is about ₩23,800, so the case itself saves only about ₩450. Most of the gap comes from printing the handwriting instead of engraving it. It misses above about ₩7,400 an engraving job, or about $4.95 a case; Soomgo's engraving average is ₩11,000. Your own fiber laser marker, a small engraving laser, cuts it to about ₩17,000, and the semi-custom case to about ₩17,600: the marker, not the case, is the big saving.
What does it change?	Cash, minimums and time, more than cost. Cases are bought from 10 for the orders in hand, so there is no batch of 285 to pay for. The most cash out at once falls from about ₩7.2M to ₩4.9M, and break-even from 104 presale orders to 85. Presale orders ship in August, not late September.
What could stop it?	Three things. No factory offers a case of 40 mm or less from 10 pieces. The case fails Korea's lead limit. Or Wadiz won't take a stock body as the reward. If lead is the only problem, use a 316L steel case. If no case exists, use the semi-custom case if about ₩9M is within reach, or else a round steel locket. If Wadiz refuses stock bodies, only the semi-custom case is left.

What already exists

Six forms come close. Prices are listing prices seen in search results, not quotes. Sizes and metals were rarely shown, so samples decide.

Form, with examples	Price and minimum	Fits the design?	Verdict
Generic photo pocket watch: Alibaba engravable pocket watches, Etsy groomsmen watches	$1.42 to $3.90, from 5 to 10; sold at $20 to $90	No: about 45 mm, alloy, quartz, the photo on the outer lid	Avoid
Watch-shaped photo locket, no movement: a flip-lid "pocket watch" photo pendant on 1688, China's domestic wholesale site; a Temu zinc-alloy pocket-watch locket	About ¥13, or ₩2,700	The shape, not the size or the metal; often zinc alloy	Prototypes only
Empty hunter case from a pocket-watch factory: one listing, a full-hunter empty case for laser engraving; dial printers from 1 to 10 pieces	Not shown. About $3 to $6 with your lid lasered on, by estimate	Yes, if a 30 to 40 mm size in low-lead brass or 316L exists	**Test first**
Round double-glass locket: Guangzhou IO Jewelry, 20, 25 and 30 mm, in 316 steel or gold-plated	$1 to $3, from 20 to 100	Partly: one window for the dial and one for the photo, but no crown, and a modern look	The fallback if cash is short
Small brass makers: Baoyan from 3 pieces, Mimier from 2, Peishang from 30	Not shown	Only if one already has a pocket-watch mould	Ask in week 1

Form, with examples	Price and minimum	Fits the design?	Verdict
Print-on-demand and Korean makers: Printify photo pendants, ShineOn, Idus photo lockets	$9 to $27 before shipping; ₩28,000 on Idus	No: flat pendants, small hearts and ovals	Avoid; Idus also bans bought-in (사입) and ODM goods

For the needle face, solid brass compass lockets list at $3 to $6 from 100 pieces. But a live needle can't be fixed on a city, so print or engrave the needle on the dial. Custom watch dials from hobby sellers cost $26 to $33 each, more than a whole locket's budget, so the dial is printed in Seoul.

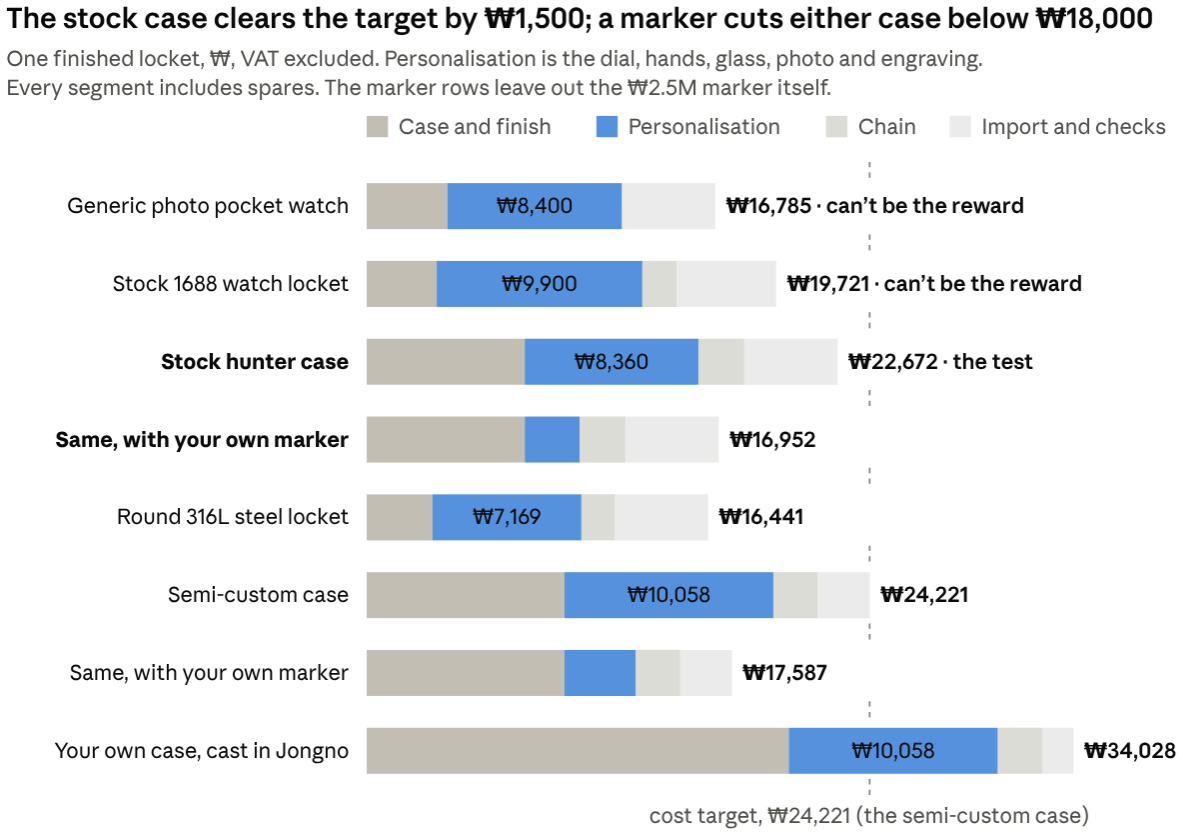
Retro, customisable or generic: six routes side by side

The stock hunter case is the cheapest route that is retro and customisable in tens. Whether Wadiz accepts it as the main reward is our reading of its rules, not Wadiz's answer, so ask Wadiz before ordering cases.

Route	Looks like Celestual	Minimum and time	Can be the Wadiz reward
Generic photo pocket watch	No	10 pieces, 2 weeks	No: the same watch is on sale everywhere
Stock 1688 watch locket	Partly: the shape	10 pieces, 3 weeks	No: the same item is on sale
Stock hunter case, your lid lasered on	**Yes, at 30 to 40 mm, preferring 38 mm or less**	**Not shown; ask for 10. About 3 weeks**	**Probably, if the page says how it is made. Ask Wadiz first**
Round 316L steel locket	Partly: no crown, and a modern look	20 to 100 pieces, 3 weeks	Only with your own mark and dial, and only if Wadiz accepts a stock body
Semi-custom case, the fallback	Yes: 36 mm, engine-turned	100 to 300 pieces, 8 weeks	Yes
Your own case, cast in Jongno	Yes: a shape only you own	No formal minimum; about 30 in the model. 12 to 16 weeks	Yes

- **What you can make your own:** on the generic watch, only its outer lid. On the 1688 and steel lockets, the dial, time, photo and engraving, and your mark on the steel one. On the stock hunter case, everything but its shape: lid, dial, time, photo, engraving, box and letter. The semi-custom and cast cases add the handwriting engraved inside the lid.
- **Metal and engraving:** the generic watch and the 1688 locket are often zinc alloy, the metal that fails Korea's limits most. Engraving through their plating shows grey. 316L steel is the safest metal and engraves cleanly. The stock hunter case must be low-lead brass or 316L, tested before sale.

What each route costs



docs/strategy/model/routes.py · listing prices and estimates, no supplier has quoted · 18 Oct 2026

Among the China routes, the case changes the cost by a few thousand won. Engraving, the box and your time are where the money goes. Only the Jongno cast case is dear.

Route	Single, boxed	Left per presale order: single, pair	Starting cost; break-even
Generic photo pocket watch, at ₩45,000 and ₩79,000, if Wadiz took it	₩19,500	₩6,900 and ₩15,300	₩2.5M; 138 orders

Route	Single, boxed	Left per presale order: single, pair	Starting cost; break-even
Stock 1688 watch locket	₩25,400	₩30,300 and ₩57,300	₩3.0M; 58 orders
Stock hunter case	**₩28,400**	**₩26,900 and ₩50,500**	**₩4.0M; 85 orders**
Round 316L steel locket	₩22,100	₩34,100 and ₩64,900	₩3.7M; 63 orders
Semi-custom case	₩34,400	₩20,000 and ₩40,500	₩4.0M; 104 orders
Your own case, cast in Jongno	₩44,200	₩8,600 and ₩17,900	₩3.6M; 176 orders

- **What is left:** the price less making, the Wadiz fee, shipping, defects and ₩7,000 an order for your own posts: props, gifts and tools. No VAT is due, as in the Economics tab. Every route but the generic watch is priced at ₩79,000 and ₩139,000.
- **Like for like:** built to the semi-custom spec, the stock case costs about ₩23,800 a locket and ₩34,000 a boxed single, against ₩24,200 and ₩34,400. That spec is the handwriting engraved, the custom box and the plan's engraving prices. Break-even is then about 102 orders, against 104.
- **The box:** the stock routes use a stock drawer box with a printed sleeve. With the card, chip, seal and pouch it costs about ₩5,700 a single, against ₩10,200 for the custom box. That ₩4,500 saving is an estimate, and it sits outside the per-locket figures; the custom box can come with the custom case.
- **Checks are priced in:** the small-lot routes carry ₩3,000 a locket for checks and lab re-tests, and ₩1M for the first round of lab tests.
- **What the stock case's ₩4.0M buys:**
  - April: the prototype kit and printing tools, ₩550,000; case samples by express, ₩300,000; the trademark, ₩546,000; registration, ₩50,000.
  - May: box samples and a sleeve proof, ₩50,000; the design registration of the lid and dial, ₩150,000; the lab tests, ₩1M.
  - June: the 12 early pieces, shipped, ₩360,000; photography, ₩200,000.
  - April to September: tools, ₩270,000.
  - On top: 15% for surprises, ₩521,400.
- **Cheapest is not allowed as is:** the 1688 locket can never be the reward, and the steel locket only with your own mark and dial, if Wadiz accepts a stock body.

- **What decides the cost target:** engraving first. It is ₩6,000 a job in the model. A regional blog puts a short line at ₩5,000 to ₩12,000, and Soomgo's average is ₩11,000. Above about ₩7,400 a job, the stock case misses the target; at ₩11,000, a locket costs about ₩28,200. The case price matters too: the target holds only up to about $4.95 a case, inside the $3 to $6 estimate. At $6 a locket costs about ₩25,900.
- **Your own fiber marker:** a generic 20 to 30 W engraving laser costs about ₩1.5M to ₩3.5M, including shipping, duty and VAT. Each job then costs a few hundred won, and a locket about ₩17,000. The handwriting can be engraved inside the lid again. The model's ₩2.5M marker pays back after about 245 orders. With its own marker the semi-custom case is about ₩17,600, so the marker, not the case, is the big saving.
- **When to buy the marker:** once Wadiz's first payout has landed and the first presale cases have passed the lab, if the presale has 100 orders or more, or 60 or more with a quote above ₩10,000 a job. Try it on the spare cases first, and keep the Jongno shop booked for the presale run.
- **Your time is not in these costs:** about 35 to 60 minutes a locket, so 100 presale orders take 90 to 150 hours. A helper for half those hours costs about ₩0.5M to ₩0.8M at the minimum wage, also outside the model.
- **Cash:**
  - The stock case pays for the presale's cases on the close, about two weeks before Wadiz's first payout lands, by our estimate. So it is most out of pocket in mid-July, about ₩4.9M.
  - That counts only the cases. Buy the chains, boxes, cards and other parts after the payout lands; they take days to two weeks.
  - The dip grows with the presale, by about ₩160,000 for each 10 orders above 100. Above about 135 orders, ask the factory for a deposit on the close and the balance on shipping.
  - The semi-custom case orders its batch once the payout lands, and is most out at the end of September, about ₩7.2M.
  - Keep about ₩9M within reach until the gates pass in early June, then about ₩5.5M until December, as in the Economics tab. The stock case with the marker bought in August needs about ₩5.2M at a 60% payout.
  - The stock case is back above zero in October, or November with the marker; the semi-custom case in December.
- **If the presale fails:** about ₩3.4M is lost on either route. If Wadiz charged 25 backers anyway, the loss is about ₩2.2M instead of ₩3.1M, because there is no 100-case minimum to buy. The custom box's minimum would add to the semi-custom loss.

The rules that decide it

1. **Wadiz won't take a product that is already on sale.** Its review policy rules out a main reward whose identical product was sold or pre-sold before submission through another official channel, in Korea or abroad. The page must also say how the reward is made. In 2019 a toothbrush found on Taobao at a tenth of the price had its funding ended early. Since 2021 Wadiz also checks that the maker planned and developed the item, and checks its appearance. So:
   - a stock 1688 locket, even engraved, is a prototype, never the reward;
   - the reward is new where people look: your lid, your dial, the stopped time, the photo, the engraving, the box and the letter;
   - the page says "case made by a partner factory in China to our lid design; dial printed, hands set, photo fitted, engraving and assembly by hand in Seoul";
   - nothing is sold or pre-sold anywhere before the Wadiz submission, SmartStore and Instagram included;
   - whether a stock body passes is our reading, not Wadiz's answer, so ask Wadiz in writing in week 1.
2. **Korea bans metal jewellery with more than 0.009% lead** (90 mg/kg), for imports since July 2024 and for sales since January 2025. Cadmium of 0.1% or more is banned too, and nickel release is held to 0.5 µg/cm² a week. The lead and cadmium limits are in the environment ministry's restricted-substance notice under the chemicals law (화평법). The ministry was renamed in October 2025, so read the current notice on law.go.kr. The nickel limit is reported by the press; its legal source was not found. The limits bind both the importer and the seller.
   - That is stricter than the 0.05% this plan used until now, and ordinary brass is far above it.
   - Cheap marketplace jewellery fails often: 96 of 404 AliExpress and Temu pieces at Incheon customs in 2024, at 10 to 700 times the limits.
   - So a Korean test lab checks the first lot of each metal part from each supplier before anything is sold. That costs an estimated ₩150,000 to ₩400,000 per material.
   - After that, keep the supplier's report for every lot. Lab-test one lot in three, and any lot after a change of supplier, alloy or plating. Buy chains and clasps 200 at a time, so they are tested rarely.
3. **Imports for resale need a formal declaration.** Bringing in goods you sell through the quick customs lane for personal parcels (목록통관) counts as smuggling. Import under the business number and pay 8% duty plus 10% VAT. The Korea–China FTA lists 0% for

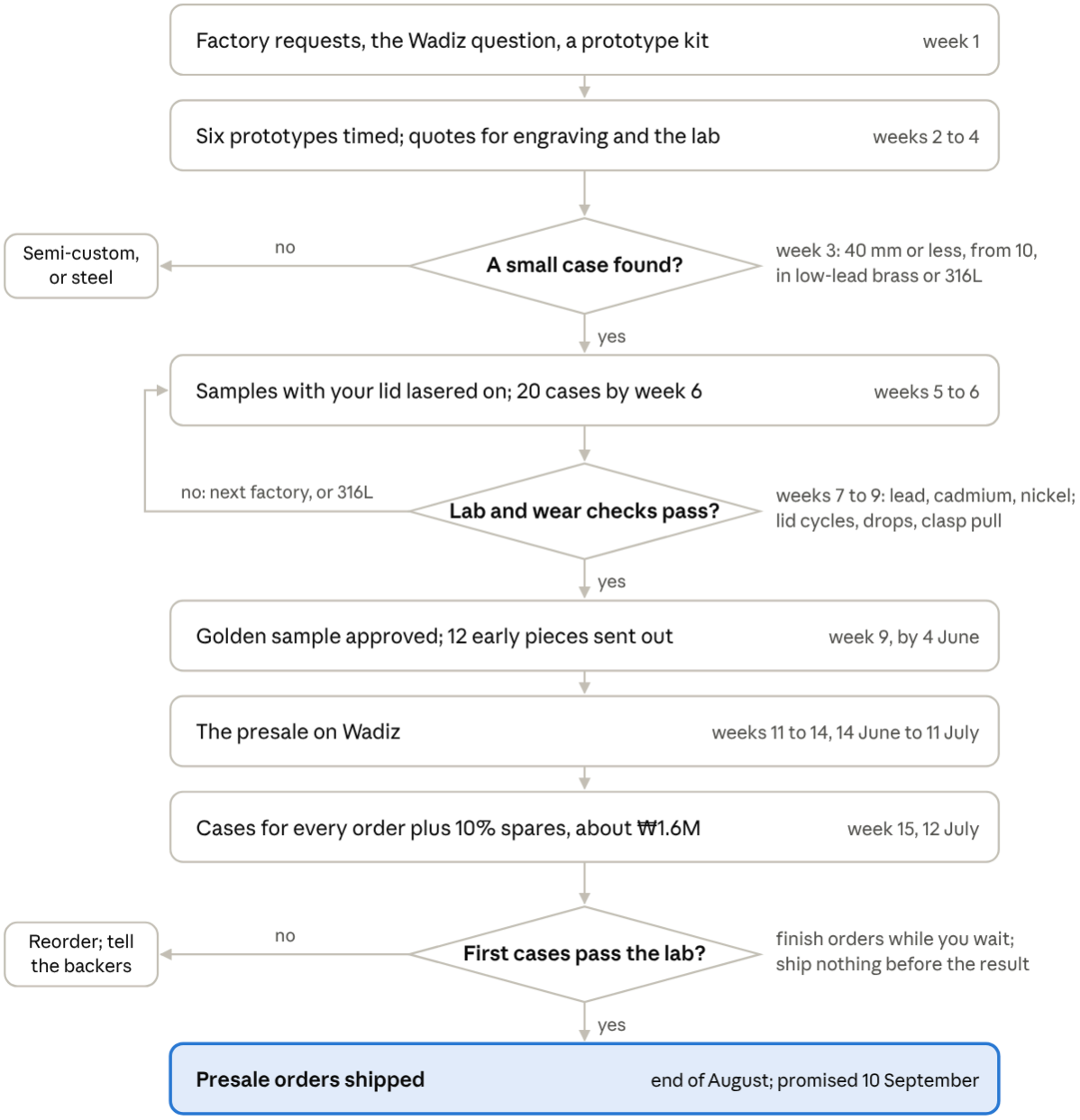
chains. It covers the case only if the case's own line also shows 0% and the factory issues a certificate of origin. Ask the broker which line an empty watch case falls under. Mark "Made in China" on the tag or the box, and say "finished by hand in Seoul".

4. **Wadiz pays 60 to 80% when the funding's payments complete,** by its guide, and the rest after the last delivery and the refund process. Run the presale as reward funding (펀딩) with a goal, not as Wadiz's pre-order type (프리오더). A pre-order needs a special benefit, and its special-bundle and limited-edition versions are paid only afterwards. Confirm the split for your project; the model assumes 70%.
5. **Not Idus or Tumblbug.** Idus bans bought-in (사입) and ODM goods (made to a factory's own design), inspects workshops, and removes sellers who break the rule. Tumblbug bars projects that buy goods to pass on.

From discharge to the first shipments

Weeks count from discharge, assumed early April 2027. Nothing is ordered before it. The presale stays at 14 June to 11 July only if the samples pass on time. If they slip, move it once, by up to four weeks, as the plan allows. These weeks also hold the business registration, the waitlist push, both IP filings, the first in-person 11:11 night and the order-step build. If they overrun, move the 11:11 night to after the presale first.

About 21 weeks from discharge to buyers' hands, with three checks on the way



the stock-case path · weeks counted from discharge, assumed early April 2027 · lead times from the sourcing research, not quotes

1. **Week 1, by 9 April:**
   - Send the requests in the next section to five pocket-watch case factories and three Guangzhou brass makers.
   - Ask two semi-custom case factories for a quote at 100 pieces, so the fallback doesn't start from zero at week 3.
   - Ask Wadiz in writing whether a stock body can be the main reward: a stock hunter case with your lid, dial, photo and engraving, or a stock round steel locket with your mark, dial and photo. Ask about both in one message, and ask how long its review takes and whether the waitlist page needs it first.

- Have the lid file ready, and a draft supply agreement to send the chosen factory. Wadiz has asked makers whose design a factory produces (OEM) for both.
- Order a prototype kit: two or three each of four stock bodies, plus real watch hands, glass domes, 25 and 30 mm circle punches and UV glue. The bodies are a generic photo watch to compare against, the 1688 watch locket, a small pendant watch and a 30 mm steel locket. About ₩550,000 with the printing tools.
- AliExpress items on 5 to 7 day delivery come first; the rest takes 2 to 4 weeks.
- The lid and dial files must be ready. If the lawyer did not allow design work before discharge, add a week.

2. **Weeks 2 to 4:** build six prototypes as the kit arrives, and time every step. Compare a printed dial with real hands against a fully printed one, try the needle face, and check that two faces fit the photo window. Get a fixed price per job from a Jongno 3-ga engraver, and quotes from two customs brokers for a small formal import. Ask a Korean test lab, KTR, KCL or FITI, for a quote.
3. **Week 3, the gate, by 23 April:** does any factory offer a hunter case of 40 mm or less from 10 pieces? It must be brass with a stated lead content under 0.009%, or 316L steel. If yes, order samples with your lid lasered on from the best two, about ₩300,000 by express.
   - If no case exists, use the semi-custom case if you can keep about ₩9M within reach, and move the presale back about three weeks, which uses its one move. Otherwise use the round steel locket.
   - If the only problem is lead, go to steel: a custom brass case has the same problem.
4. **Weeks 5 and 6:** the samples arrive. Check the dial seat, the photo recess in the lid, the hinge and the snap. Send one of each, with a chain and a clasp, to the lab. Photos of the real prototype, labelled 시제품, replace the concept renders on the waitlist page.
   - If Wadiz has said yes, order 20 cases from the better factory, about ₩170,000: 10 for creators, a pair to film, and spares. Ask the factory to confirm they are the same alloy and plating as the sample.
   - If Wadiz hasn't answered by week 5, chase it. With still no answer by week 6, order the 20 anyway: ₩170,000 is the price of keeping 14 June.
5. **Weeks 7 to 9, the second gate: the lab result.** The case, chain and clasp must pass.
   - If the better factory's case fails, use the second factory's if it passed, and reorder the 20 cases from it. If both fail, order and test a 316L case. Move the presale back once, by up to four weeks, if the early pieces can't go out in time.
   - Build the golden sample, the finished piece every later one must match. Run the plan's wear checks: 500 open-and-close cycles, three 1 m drops, heat and cold, and a 3 to 5 kg pull on the clasp.

    - Submit the project to Wadiz's review with the sample photos as soon as the lab passes, so a no at review still leaves time to move the presale once.
6. **Week 9, by 4 June:** approve the golden sample and send out the 12 early pieces.
7. **The presale, 14 June to 11 July.** If the goal is met, order cases for every presale order on 12 July, plus 10% spares, about ₩1.6M; they arrive in 2 to 3 weeks. Send the first presale cases to the lab the day they arrive. Finish orders while you wait, but ship nothing until the result is in.
8. **From late July:** personalise the presale orders. That is 90 to 150 hours of work, so the helper you lined up by March starts on day one. Ship by the end of August; the page promises 10 September. Then, each month, order the next month's cases.
9. **Move to the semi-custom case** once the shop sells 40 orders a month, or once reviews name the stock case as the weak point. It is 36 mm, with an engine-turned lid and the handwriting engraved inside. Pay its 100-piece minimum from sales, not savings.

What to send suppliers

To pocket-watch case factories, through Alibaba or Made-in-China, in week 1:

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Request for quotation: empty hunter pocket-watch case, no movement
- Full-hunter case, the smallest you make between 30 and 40 mm (38 mm or less preferred): crown and bow, hinged front lid with a snap, crystal fitted, back left blank
- Inside the case: a seat or spacer ring for a printed dial with no movement, and a centre post for fixed hands
- Inside the front lid: a flat recess for a 25 to 30 mm photo under flat or low-domed glass; tell us its depth and the gap to the crystal
- Material: brass with lead below 0.009% (90 mg/kg) and cadmium below 0.01% by weight (the EU limit), in the base metal, plating and solder; or 316L stainless steel
- A test report for this item: lead and cadmium content, and nickel release (EN 1811)
- Our pattern laser-engraved on the front lid, from our vector file; our mark inside the back cover, not the lid
- Finish: polished brass under clear lacquer, no nickel under-plate
- Measurements and photos with a ruler: diameter, thickness, lid recess, crystal and weight
- Prices at 10, 50 and 100 pieces; sample price and time with our engraving; production time
- Our lid pattern is ours: do not sell it to others, and sign a short supply agreement that says so
- Individual bags; a commercial invoice stating the country of origin; a Korea-China FTA certificate of origin, if you can issue one
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To the Guangzhou brass makers: do you already have a pocket-watch-shaped photo locket mould? Can you make it in brass with lead below 0.009%, at 30 to 50 pieces, with our lid pattern?

In Seoul, in week 2:

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[각인] 황동 또는 316L 스테인리스 회중시계형 펜던트 뒷면 1줄 레이저 각인, 지름 30~40 mm (38 mm 이하 우선), 벡터 파일 제공. 문구는 개당 다름(개별 각인). 10개 / 50개 / 100개 기준 건당 단가와 소요 기간을 알려주세요.
[시험] 금속 장신구 납·카드뮤 함량 및 니켈 용출(EN 1811) 시험: 케이스 2종, 체인 1종, 고리 1종. 수수료와 기간을 알려주세요.
[통관] 중국산 금속 장신구 소량 일반수입신고(사업자 통관) 건당 수수료를 알려주세요. 빈 회중시계 케이스(무브먼트 없음)의 HS 분류(7117.19 또는 9111)와 한중 FTA 협정세율도 알려주세요.
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Risks, and what to do

Risk	The sign	What to do
No small case exists	Week-3 replies offer only 45 mm cases, or zinc alloy	The semi-custom case at 100 pieces if about ₩9M is within reach, moving the presale about three weeks; or the steel locket
Wadiz says no to a stock body	Its answer in weeks 1 to 6, or at review	The semi-custom case if about ₩9M is within reach, and move the presale. The steel locket only if Wadiz's answer allows its body
The case fails the lead test	A lab result over 0.009%	The second factory's case if it passed, or a 316L case; sell nothing from the failed lot
The case can't hold the photo or the dial	The samples in weeks 5 and 6	Ask the factory for a lid recess and a dial seat; if it can't, the next factory or the steel locket
The presale lot fails the lab	A result over 0.009% in August	Ship nothing from it. Reorder from the second factory, tell backers the new date, and refund anyone who asks

Risk	The sign	What to do
Customs holds a lot for testing	A customs notice, or a lot that is late	Keep the supplier's report and your lab result with the import papers; the promise date has 10 days to spare
A backer finds the case on AliExpress	A comment, a DM, or a question from Wadiz	The page already says where the case is made and what is yours; answer with that, and never deny it. Wadiz has ended projects over this, so have its written view before you submit
Engraving costs more than ₩6,000 a job	The Jongno quote in week 2	Above about ₩7,400 a job, the stock case misses the cost target. Buy the fiber marker by the rule under "When to buy the marker"
Stock cases vary	Loose hinges, weak snaps, crystals off centre	Check every piece, and buy 10% spares
The work runs slow	Under 8 orders finished a day in the first week; that pace is 7 to 12 hours a day for one person	Two people from the first day. A helper for half the hours costs about ₩0.5M to ₩0.8M at the minimum wage; the promise date has 10 days to spare

Sources

Search results read on 18 October 2026, not opened pages. The full notes are in docs/strategy/research/F-starting.md, and the costs come from docs/strategy/model/routes.py.

- Wadiz: reward review policy · fee and settlement policy · the notice on OEM rewards · stricter review from 2021, ktnews · the toothbrush ended early, etnews 2019
- Metal limits: Korea's 0.009% lead limit, ChemLinked · Gunsan customs tests, Tax Times · Incheon customs tests, Aju News
- Import: the personal-parcel lane for resale counts as smuggling, Taxwatch · the FTA rate for 7117.19
- Other platforms: Idus selling rules · Tumblbug project rules

- Personalisation: engraving prices, Soomgo · fiber laser marker listings · engraving plated zinc alloy, Sourcify